

Axolotl Water Parameter Log

Print this page and keep it taped near the tank. Test weekly at minimum — more often during the first 8 weeks of cycling or after any water quality scare.

Target Ranges

Parameter	Target	Danger zone
Temperature	59-64°F (15-18°C)	Above 75°F (24°C)
pH	7.4-7.6	Below 6.0
Ammonia (NH3)	0 ppm	Above 0.1 ppm
Nitrite (NO2-)	0 ppm	Above 0.5 mg/L
Nitrate (NO3-)	Under 10 mg/L	Above 50 mg/L
General Hardness	7-14° dGH	Too soft

Weekly Test Log

Date	Temp	pH	NH3	NO2-	NO3-	Water changed?	Notes

Tip: a sudden jump in any reading is more useful information than the absolute number. Compare this week to last week, not just to the target range.

New Axolotl Setup Checklist

Work through this in order. The single biggest first-month killer is skipping the cycling step — everything above it should be done and stable before an axolotl goes in the tank.

Before You Buy

- ☐ Confirmed axolotls are legal to own in your state/city (banned in CA, ME, NJ, DC, AR; permit required in NM and HI)
- ☐ Budgeted \$200-600 for upfront setup plus \$25-40/month ongoing
- ☐ Have a plan for a chiller if your room regularly runs above 70°F
- ☐ Found a source for live or frozen earthworms/nightcrawlers, not just pellets

Tank & Equipment

- ☐ Tank is 20 gallons minimum, 29-40 gallons preferred — length and width over height
- ☐ Tight-fitting lid or hood in place (axolotls jump)
- ☐ Filter rated for 3-6x tank volume turnover per hour, with output baffled or diffused
- ☐ Substrate is bare glass, fine sand under 1mm, or smooth slate — no standard gravel
- ☐ Chiller installed and tested if room temperature runs warm
- ☐ Thermometer placed where you'll actually see it daily
- ☐ Hiding spots (caves, tubes, smooth driftwood) added — no sharp edges

Before the Axolotl Arrives

- ☐ Tank has been running and cycling for 4-8 weeks
- ☐ Ammonia and nitrite both reading 0 ppm for at least a week straight
- ☐ Nitrate under 10 mg/L
- ☐ Water conditioner on hand — checked it does NOT contain aloe vera or plant extracts
- ☐ Liquid test kit on hand (not just paper strips)
- ☐ First food source ready (earthworms, nightcrawlers, or sinking pellets)

Ongoing Routine

- ☐ Daily: check temperature, remove uneaten food
- ☐ Weekly: test ammonia/nitrite/nitrate/pH, change 20-30% of water
- ☐ Monthly: rinse filter media in old tank water (never tap water)
- ☐ Watch for: curled gills, persistent floating, pale gills, white fuzzy patches, red sores

Companion resource to the full Axolotl Care Guide. Not a substitute for veterinary care — if your axolotl shows signs of illness that don't resolve with a water change, contact an exotics-experienced vet.